

THE STRINGS PULLED
Devendra Fadnavis at a BJP rally on Maharashtra Day, May 2, 2022

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FADNAVIS HAD AT FIRST CHOSEN TO PLAY THE NON-PLAYING CAPTAIN, BUT THE BJP PERSUADED HIM TO BE DEPUTY CM

Rajesh Kshirsagar. For the bypoll in April necessitated by Jadhav's death, Uddhav accepted the Congress's claim on the seat and asked Kshirsagar to campaign for the GOP. The Congress won that bypoll, Uddhav lost Kshirsagar to the Shinde camp.

Rebel MLA Sanjay Gaikwad says the NCP was actually funding his rival in his constituency Buldhana, but Uddhav chose silence. "The NCP was on a mission to systematically corner us in our own area. We had clearly told Saheb (Uddhav) to snap ties with the NCP-Congress as they were harming us." Kesarkar echoes this. "Some 45 Sena MLAs have a direct fight either with the NCP or Congress in their constituencies," he says. "We were fighting to save our existence. We looked to Uddhavji for backing, but he was unwilling to take a stand."

Gulabrao Patil, another key rebel MLA, adds: "Uddhavji chose to risk losing his official residence and 40 MLAs but not Pawar. The attitude was detrimental."

Alongside this, there was that other flaw not unknown among India's political dynasts: the tendency to concentrate power within the family. All the rebels cite how Uddhav underlined to party workers and ministers that his inexperienced son Aaditya would call the shots in all important matters. The seniors were bound to find this frustrating. Aaditya, who became the second-most powerful person after his father, soon started calling meetings with officials outside his portfolios of tourism and environment. Shinde and others naturally saw this as an intrusion. Nor did Aaditya set up parallel lines with the rank and file to compensate for the absentee lord. Neither did it stop with Aaditya. Uddhav thought nothing of allowing another family novice, Varun Sardesai, to dominate over seniors. The 30-year-old nephew of Thackeray's ambitious wife Rashmi, too, became a mini-power centre, reportedly with a penchant for issuing instructions on behalf of Uddhav. Almost all ministers and MLAs resented this.

The coterie of favourite officials added to the alienation of partymen and officials. Former chief secretary Ajoy Mehta was Uddhav's Man Friday—every single file the CM cleared (or held his hand on) passed through him. And after